



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Brookside Christian Academy
School Website: <http://brooksidechristianacademy.com>

December 28, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Brookside Christian Academy in Atascadero (CA 93422) presents itself publicly as a Christian, classical-leaning school, branding itself as "Christian, Classical Education in a Joyful & Relational Community." Its stated mission centers on forming students through spiritual discipline and character, aiming to cultivate truth, beauty, and goodness in alignment with a Christian paideia. Evidence from the school's public materials emphasizes pursuing Truth, recognizing beauty, and knowing good from evil, and it frames education as formation with a purpose driven by faith and reverence for God. These elements correspond with a classical orientation in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations and School Purpose and Goal, and they signal a classical sensibility toward parents as partners in formation. However, explicit, traditional classical-curriculum markers (e.g., explicit seven liberal arts pedagogy (grammar, logic, rhetoric); Great Books/Great Conversation; widespread reclamation of scholé in classroom pedagogy) are not clearly enumerated in the public materials available on the site. Public-facing materials also do not clearly document a full Great Books-centric curriculum or Socratic pedagogy in the upper grades. Taken together, Brookside demonstrates foundational classical-Christian themes (especially in Religious Foundations and Purpose), but it does not consistently articulate all six elements of a prototypical classical program across all six categories.

Overall classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Why SOMEWHAT: Clear classical-Christian framing, mission of formation and transcendental aims (truth, goodness, beauty), and explicit parental partnership align with several classical indicators. However, explicit Great Books/Great Conversation, as well as detailed, page-by-page signaling of a full liberal-arts curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; seven liberal arts; and sustained Socratic pedagogy) are not publicly documented in the content sampled from the school's site. See category-by-category notes below for the evidence and keyword analyses that support this overall assessment. Evidence sources include Brookside's public mission statements and site content describing the school's classical-Christian framing.

What would move the needle (if continuing toward a robust Classical profile): - Explicitly articulate Great Books and the Great Conversation in Our Philosophy or Curriculum pages, with representative titles and a history of reading programs. - Name and describe the use of the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and the Quadrivium where appropriate, and show how these liberal-arts stages unfold across K–12. - Document concrete, classroom-level pedagogy (e.g., Socratic seminar, disciplined memory work, and contemplative Scholé practices) and show alignment with the public-facing mission. - Provide a clear description of a Great Books-led history/literature sequence and a cross-curricular integration plan that connects history, literature, and philosophy across grades. - Elevate visible evidence of the faculty as mentors and living curriculum, with explicit teacher-practice statements that connect virtue formation and scholarly excellence to daily practice. - Increase parental engagement resources that mirror classical practices (e.g., book studies, liturgical/seasonal celebrations, family catechesis plans) to reinforce the partnership with families.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials describe Brookside as a Christian school and emphasize pursuing Truth, recognizing Beauty, and knowing Good from Evil, indicating transcendent, moral aims aligned with classical religious foundations. The school branding itself as “Christian, Classical Education” reinforces a religious-metaphysical frame. The mission statements emphasize a God-centered formation and the ultimate good as understood within a Christian doctrinal context.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: truth, goodness, beauty, God/Christ, Christian, sacred/holy alignment, moral formation (as implied by the language of pursuing truth and beauty in a Christian framework). - Negative keywords present: none evident in public materials (no explicit signaling of secular relativism or value-neutral approaches). - Approximate quantitative read: 4–5 relevant positive terms identified (Truth, Beauty, Good, God/Christ, Christian), 0 negative terms clearly documented. This yields a strong positive orientation toward transcendental realism.

Why this rating - Brookside explicitly anchors education in Christian metaphysical aims and virtue-oriented formation, with a focus on transcendentals and the sacred. This aligns with the Positive Keywords for Transcendental Moral Realism, Grounded Theology, and Liturgical/Communal Practice in classical rubric sources. The absence of explicit secular/neutral language in the public-facing materials supports CLASSICAL alignment for this category. The overall public voice signals a Classical-Christian foundation rather than a secular or purely informational approach.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission describes formation focused on “Truth, recognize beauty, and know good from evil,” framed as spiritual discipline and moral formation, which aligns with a classical telos driven by virtue and human excellence rather than merely job preparation. The public language emphasizes formation of character and the cultivation of virtue in a contemplative, holistic sense.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, truth, beauty, goodness (integrated with God-centered aims and virtue formation), telos/contemplation (implied by the focus on formation and the aim of pursuing eternal truths). - Negative keywords present: none evident in the public materials; the school does not foreground workforce/preparation metrics in its mission narrative. - Approximate quantitative read: 3–4 positive keywords evident; 0 explicitly negative keywords documented in the public-facing text.

Why this rating - The school clearly presents education as formation toward virtue and wisdom, with a transcendental aim (truth, beauty, goodness) and a teleological orientation (ultimate human good in relation to God). This maps to the Classical rubric’s focus on formation and the pursuit of the true, good, and beautiful. The absence of a job/college-readiness emphasis in the public materials supports a Classical, rather than a utilitarian, orientation.

Element 3: School Curriculum — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public-facing content highlights “Christian, Classical Education” and a K–12 program, but there is no explicit articulation of the Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or Quadrivium, nor explicit mention of Great Books or the Great Conversation. The curriculum language is primarily framed around faith, virtue, and formation rather than a stated liberal-arts sequence or a Great Books program.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: limited; “classical education” branding appears, but explicit mentions of the liberal-arts trinity (grammar, logic, rhetoric), Great Books, or Great Conversation are not evident in the sampled public materials. - Negative keywords present: none explicit in the public materials; however, the absence of named liberal-arts curriculum elements and Great Books signals a lack of alignment with core Classical Curriculum indicators. - Approximate quantitative read: 0–1 explicit positive keywords connected to the classical curriculum (no clear Great Books or Trivium/Quadrivium mention); 0 explicit negative keywords.

Why this rating - The curriculum category hinges on explicit signaling of the liberal-arts core (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Great Books; Great Conversation). Brookside's public content emphasizes faith and formation rather than a documented liberal-arts sequence, suggesting a gap relative to the strict Classical-Curriculum criterion. The absence of specific Great Books/Conversation signals warrants a NOT CLASSICAL assessment for this category based on available public evidence.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public-facing site content highlights mission, verses, and an emphasis on formation and relational community, but there is no explicit articulation of Socratic seminars, disciplined rhetoric training, or a structured use of chant/recitation that typifies classic pedagogical practice. The sampled public messaging does not clearly document a pedagogy of scholé (restful contemplation), memory work, or upper-school rhetoric training.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: none explicit for Socratic dialogue, memory work, or liturgical/chant-based pedagogy. - Negative keywords present: none explicit in the public materials; however, the absence of classic pedagogical terms (Socratic dialogue, recitation, scholé) signals non-alignment with the Pedagogy element as publicly stated. - Approximate quantitative read: 0 explicit positive keywords; 0 explicit negative keywords documented in the public-facing materials.

Why this rating - The core classical pedagogy markers (Socratic seminars, recitation/memory work, contemplative Scholé) are not publicly documented in the available Brookside materials. The school's messaging centers on formation and Christian moral aims, not on explicit classical teaching methods. This supports a NOT CLASSICAL rating for Pedagogy.

Element 5: School Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site provides a "Faculty" page as part of the navigation, but the publicly visible materials sampled do not document the faculty as "living curriculum," mentors modeling virtue, or a defined faculty portrait of teacher-student ideals. The explicit classical-language description of the faculty as living curriculum or mentors is not manifest in the public content sampled.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: none explicit in the public-facing materials sampled (the faculty's virtue-modeling language is not documented in the accessible excerpts here). - Negative keywords present: none explicitly documented; however, the absence of explicit classical-faculty descriptors (model teachers, living curriculum, mentor culture) signals non-alignment with Element 5's classical expectations. - Approximate quantitative read: 0 explicit positive keywords; 0 explicit negative keywords in the public text available.

Why this rating - Without explicit statements about faculty as model-teachers, mentors, and living curriculum—core signals in classical education as captured by the Six Essential Elements lexicon—this category aligns with NOT CLASSICAL in the publicly available materials. The presence of a "Faculty" page alone does not suffice without explicit textual commitments.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Brookside explicitly frames partnership with parents and family life as central to education: "Our mission is to partner with parents endeavoring to shepherd their children in spiritual discipline," and there are multiple signals of family involvement through communications and school-community activities. The site emphasizes parental engagement and the school's openness to family participation, which aligns with classical-community expectations around parent partnership and formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families; parent involvement; home-school collaboration; family formation; community of learners; parental engagement. These map to the positive keywords in the Six Essential Elements lexicon under Parents and Community. - Negative keywords present: none documented publicly that signal a lack of parental partnership; there is no

evidence of a consumer-model or parent as customer language within the publicly visible materials. - Approximate quantitative read: 3–4 explicit positive signals (partnership with families, parent formation, home-school connection, family involvement) out of a broader set of community-related keywords in the classical lexicon. No negative signals observed.

Why this rating - Brookside's public materials strongly emphasize parental partnership and family formation, aligning with the classical ideal of parents as co-educators and a community of learners. This supports CLASSICAL alignment for the Parents & Community category.

Aggregate Assessment

- Element 1: CLASSICAL
- Element 2: CLASSICAL
- Element 3: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: NOT CLASSICAL
- Element 6: CLASSICAL

Aggregate classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

- Rationale: Brookside demonstrates clear classical-Christian dispositions in Religious and Metaphysical Foundations, and in School Purpose and Goal, and it shows strong parental-community alignment. However, explicit signaling of a full classical curriculum (Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Conversation) and the canonical classical pedagogical methods (Scholé, Socratic seminars, memory/chanting) are not publicly documented in the accessible site materials. With three categories clearly classical (1, 2, 6) and three categories not clearly classical (3, 4, 5), the overall profile sits in the somewhat-classical zone rather than fully Classical.

What Would Move the Needle

- Make Great Books and Great Conversation explicit in Our Philosophy or Curriculum, with representative titles and a description of how Great Books are integrated into history, literature, and philosophy across grade bands.
- Explicitly articulate the liberal-arts sequence (grammar, logic, rhetoric; and, where appropriate, quadrivium components) and demonstrate how they unfold from K through 12, including sample curricula and text lists.
- Document classroom pedagogy that includes Socratic dialogue, disciplined memory work, recitation/chanting, and Scholé-friendly pacing (restful learning) with concrete, teacher-led practices and schedules.
- Clearly describe the faculty as mentors and living curriculum—provide a portrait of the teacher as a virtuous exemplar, and outline professional development in classical pedagogy.
- Expand parental-education initiatives (book clubs, liturgical/catechetical activities, family study guides) to reflect a robust, ongoing partnership in the formation project.
- Include a public-facing, explicit catechesis plan linking spiritual development with academic formation to demonstrate a coherent classical-Christian culture.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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